as the assistant military adviser. Since I was in Delhi in any case, I went to meet him to seek his advice. He was also as shocked as anyone else, as I was considered to be a rising star of the Regiment. He told me that Gen Malik had been equally surprised at the outcome. He was certain that there was some aberration in my service profile, in my annual confidential reports (ACR), that needed looking into and advised me to file a non-statutory complaint. To seek redress from any perceived wrongdoing or harm is an accepted procedure and I did not have to shy away from it. I remembered that my cousin, Sanjay Naravane, had also not been approved but he had been too much of a 'gentleman', accepted the decision and moved on with his life. Col Kapur was not of that view, saying I must fight for my rights. When I told him that I didn't know the first thing about writing a complaint, he directed me to a Col Sakhuja who was then a Director in the Complaints and Advisory Board (CAB), which functions directly under the COAS.

The CAB deals with hundreds of complaints every year, mostly concerning supersession and being wrongfully harmed in the ACR. In processing each complaint, the Directors assigned to each individual case go into a lot of detail, not only of what is on the record but also off the record by digging deep into the background of the complaint, incidents involved, the reputation of the dramatis personae and so on, to form a more rounded picture. Over a period of time, especially when a number of complaints are received against the same superior officer, a pattern begins to emerge, suggesting that the complainant may be right in his apprehensions. The past profile of the complainant is checked and compared to see if there is a sudden spike or drop somewhere, showing either favouritism or vindictiveness. When I met Col Sakhuja, he asked me to narrate my record of service and any incidents that might have hurt my

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